

For example, when you install Yahoo! Messenger, the program is installed system-wide, but the user information is specific to the currently logged-in user. Any preferences that are made are stored under the username in the registry. If another user logs in and starts Yahoo! Messenger, the default preferences are initialised, and a new entry is created in the Registry under this username.

This flexibility has deeper significance when considering a networked scenario. Administrators can specify user rights and access to various system and network components. They can control what users can and cannot do on their machines with a fair degree of granular control. For example, Administrators can specify that users are not allowed to install new applications on their machines. A Registry entry disabling the users' right to install would secure the system. And a Registry entry can be made to prevent unauthorized access to the registry itself!

However, the Registry has not done away entirely with the legacy of INI files, partially due to Microsoft's commitment to backward compatibility and partially because in some cases the Registry wouldn't be available—as in the case of the boot process, when the boot.ini file is used to get the initial startup information.

Critics of the Registry concept point to it as a “single point of failure.” If the Registry is damaged, XP will fail to start up, and in most cases will require a complete reinstall. It is for this reason that the Registry is hidden deep in the system, and any discussion on the tweaking the Registry is accompanied by dire warnings of disaster if one does anything wrong. Also, if an application doesn't uninstall correctly, it can leave traces in the registry, which over time will increase its size and affect performance.

Physically, the Registry information in XP is stored in multiple files in the `\System32\Config` folder of the operating system (or root) folder—usually `C:\Windows` or `C:\WINNT`. These files cannot be edited directly; they have to be accessed through a Registry-editing program such as `Regedit.exe` or `Regedt32.exe`.